



MyGurukul

SACRED WISDOM — SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 14, 2026



SACRED TEXT

āpadaṃ nistared vaiśyaḥ kāmaṃ vārdhuṣakarmaṇā | 01.098a
āpatsv api hi kaṣṭāsu brāhmaṇasya na vārdhuṣam || 98 || 01.098c
brāhmaṇasya tu yad deyaṃ sāvayasya na cāsti saḥ | 01.099a
svakulyasyāsyā nivapet tadabhāve 'sya bandhuṣu || 99 || 01.099c

— Nāradaśmṛti, Chapter 1, Verse 1

GURU'S INTERPRETATION

It speaks directly to the roles and responsibilities of different members of society, specifically the Vaiśya (merchant class) and the Brāhmaṇa (priestly class). The text permits the Vaiśya to engage in usury, lending money with interest, during times of distress. This was seen as a necessary, albeit potentially problematic, means for them to navigate economic hardship and maintain their livelihoods. However, the passage explicitly prohibits the Brāhmaṇa from engaging in usury, even during dire circumstances. This prohibition stems from the Brāhmaṇa's societal role as a spiritual guide and knowledge holder, whose focus should remain on dharma and the well-being of the community, rather than the accumulation of wealth through potentially exploitative means.

Furthermore, the verses address the responsibility towards a Brāhmaṇa who is in need and has descendants. If such a Brāhmaṇa lacks the means to support his family, the community, specifically his own lineage or relatives, is obligated to provide for him. This highlights the interconnectedness of society and the importance of mutual support, especially towards those dedicated to spiritual pursuits.

In modern life, this wisdom resonates with the need for ethical considerations in all financial dealings. While the specific roles of Vaiśya and Brāhmaṇa may not translate directly, the underlying principles remain relevant. We are all called to examine our motivations and the impact of our financial decisions on others. Are we prioritizing profit above all else, or are we considering the well-being of our community? Are we willing to support those who dedicate themselves to serving others, even when they are facing hardship? These verses prompt you to consider your own values and how they are reflected in your financial conduct. They challenge you to balance your own needs with your responsibility to contribute to a just and compassionate society. The core message is about living in accordance with your dharma, your purpose, and ensuring that your actions contribute to the greater good.

REFLECTION FOR TODAY

How can you apply the principles of ethical financial conduct, prioritizing community well-being, in your daily interactions and decisions?